

book. This can be done by using a software plug-in and holding the page up to an active webcam. Readers can watch the dragon in amazing colours, see it awakening and hear it roar—all directly on their computer screen. They can also rotate the book to view the dragon from different angles as it moves and roars.

Biodegradable credit card

Sony, Dai Nippon Printing and Mitsubishi Plastic Inc. have developed a credit card using a bio-based polymer having polylactic acid as its primary material. The card is compatible with the ISO and JIS international credit card standards, and also fulfills MasterCard card design standards.

It uses plastic derived from bio-based polymer, a substance for which there are mounting expectations as a viable new resource. The card has been mounted with both a contact IC chip and FeliCa, a contactless IC card technology developed by Sony. As a result, the card can be used as a multi-functional IC credit card mounted with applications including electronic money, point reward and gateway controls such as company and student IDs.

New file formats replacing MP3 on Net

MP3 files, which reduce the original music files to about one-tenth their size, are giving way to new file formats. Unlike MP3 files, these formats help retain most of the musical information by adopting low-compression techniques—similar to those used for .zip files—instead of packing the information much tighter.

The new file formats, such as APE, EAC and FLAC, take up more space on the hard discs of computers than the MP3 files. Most music

enthusiasts are not likely to find any audible difference between MP3 and these formats, especially when listening through standard earphones or headphones. However, for those few who prefer to listen to the music very carefully through a high-end home music system the new formats might sound better.

Splittable smartphone

Fujitsu has created a phone that breaks in to two parts. When both the parts are together, F-04B acts like a sliding number pad handset. However, when apart the keyboard area folds out to be a full QWERTY key layout, and also



Fujitsu F-04B smartphone

offers the number pad.

The 173gm phone features 12.2 megapixel camera and a separable two-module body. It comes with a 8.6cm screen, dual keyboard and an optional pico projector.

The top half contains a 8.6cm touchscreen display and most of the electronics needed for the handset to function. The radio module and antenna is also in this part. The back half has a QWERTY keyboard and the slide-out numeric keypad. The two halves stay in contact via Bluetooth up to a distance of about 10 metres.

The phone measures 11.4x5.1x20.4 cm. Standby time is 600 hours in WCDMA mode and 400 hours in GSM mode, while talk time is 300 minutes and 330 minutes, respectively.



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